



Stuck Points Framework

The Stuck Points framework offers primary care physicians a path for navigating difficult communication moments about cognitive impairment while keeping connection at the center. Acknowledging that it can feel like a fine line to walk, the framework provides steps to understand why a conversation is stuck, find common ground with patients and families, and chart a path forward.

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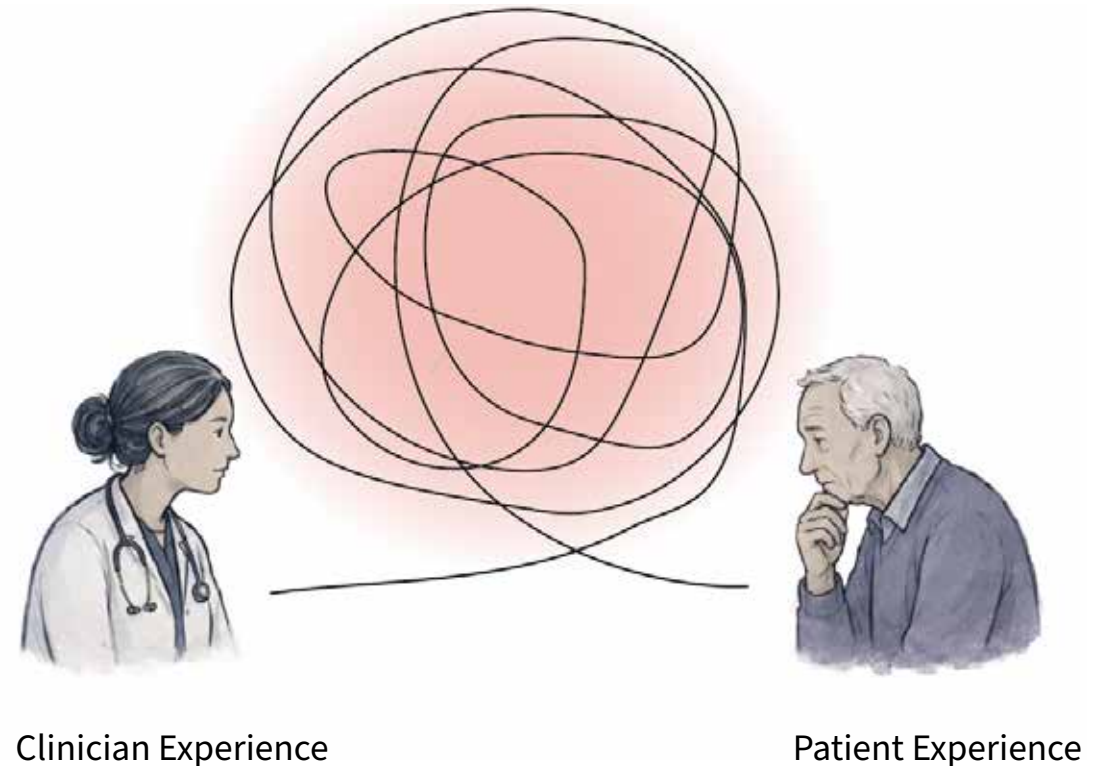
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STUCK POINTS FRAMEWORK

What is a stuck point?

“Stuck points” are moments in the dementia diagnosis journey when the conversation between a Primary Care Provider (PCP) and a patient or caregiver is not moving forward.

These challenging moments are common in delicate conversations and often bring up discomfort, uncertainty, or hesitation for clinicians. While some “stuck points” are unique to the individual or situation, many are predictable, commonly experienced roadblocks.



Stuck Points Framework

UNTANGLING STUCK POINTS

The Stuck Points framework offers 4 key steps for navigating difficult communication while keeping connection at the center.



INTERNAL

Ground Yourself

How am I feeling right now?

Pause and reset internally to notice and understand your own reactions.

- NAME
- PAUSE
- FEEL
- REFRAVE

EXTERNAL

Bridge Connection

How can I understand their experience?

Shift your stance to relate differently and create a sense of safety and connection.

- ACKNOWLEDGE
- RELATE

EXTERNAL

Explore Experience

Why are we stuck?

Explore the underlying needs and concerns that are making the conversation difficult.

- EXPLORE

EXTERNAL

Find A Path Forward

What can we try next together?

Choose a path forward by defining the next steps.

- SUMMARIZE

Ground Yourself

How am I feeling right now?



Pause and reset internally to notice and understand your own reactions.

STEP:	Notice	Pause	Feel	Reframe
	Notice you're at stuck point.	Pause, take a moment to physically reset.	Assess your internal feelings.	Make this a moment for building trust and connection.
WHAT YOU MAY THINK:	<i>"We are seeing this differently. This conversation is not moving forward."</i>	<i>"I need a moment to gather my thoughts, feelings, and reset."</i>	<i>"I feel frustrated, angry, exasperated, impatient."</i>	<i>"I imagine they feel frustrated too. My goal now is to find connection and get unstuck, not what I had originally planned for this visit."</i>
WHAT YOU MAY DO:		Find a way to create physical space: • Walk across the room • Look away • Take a deep breath • Check your pager or phone • Check patient's vital signs • Find a reason to do a part of the physical exam		

Bridge Connection

How can I understand their experience?



Shift your stance to relate differently and create a sense of safety and connection.

STEP:	Acknowledge Name the “stuck point” for everyone in the room.	Relate Address emotion before moving on.
WHAT YOU MAY THINK:	<i>“I hope we can all see we are stuck.”</i>	<i>“I can see them relaxing when I explore and acknowledge their emotion.”</i>
WHAT YOU MAY DO:	Release any tense stance: • Gently lean forward • Demonstrate open body posture • Soften and slow your voice	Acknowledge their emotions: • Name • Understand • Respect • Support • Explore
WHAT YOU MAY SAY:	“I notice that I am having some trouble knowing how to best help you right now and I’m feeling a little stuck. Would it be ok if we paused for a moment to talk about it?”	Name: “These can be scary topics.” Understand: “I can’t imagine how hard this conversation might be for you.” Respect: “I admire your courage.” Support: “We are here to help you through this.” Explore: “Can you tell me about how you are feeling now?”

Explore Experience

Why are we stuck?



Explore the underlying needs and concerns that are making the conversation difficult.

STEP:

Explore

Be curious in working to understand why you’re stuck and gently explore ways forward.

WHAT YOU MAY THINK:

“I think I am beginning to understand why we were stuck and see a path forward.”

WHAT YOU MAY DO:

- Ask open-ended, curious questions to explore underlying reasons for the stuck point.
- Build a ‘differential diagnosis’ for the stuck point (not just medical—emotional, informational, logistical, social).
- Test possible ways to help everyone move forward.

WHAT YOU MAY SAY:

- “Let’s see if we can figure this out together.”
- “What do you think is making this hard for you right now?”
- “I want to make a care plan that works for you. What is causing you the most stress right now?”
- “Can you help me understand...”

Find a Path Forward

What can we try next together?



Choose a path forward by defining the next steps.

STEP:

Summarize

You’ve clarified the reasons for the stuck point and are ready to move forward.

**WHAT YOU
MAY THINK:**

“I believe I know how we can proceed, and I would like to suggest some next steps.”

**WHAT YOU
MAY DO:**

- Summarize what you’ve heard.
- Make recommendations for next steps (follow-up, testing, continued conversation).
- Reassure ongoing support, “non-abandonment.”

**WHAT YOU
MAY SAY:**

- “Here’s what I’ve heard today…”
- “As a next step, maybe we can…?”
- “This is as far as we need to go today. Let’s plan to follow up so we can keep talking about this.”
- “We’re here for you. We’re going to do this together.”